

‘An absurd demand for significance’



Through Sartre's novels and plays, existentialism became popular among the young intellectuals of the 1950s 'Beat Generation'. Almost as influential were the novels of Sartre's friend Albert Camus, who focused not so much on the freedom to choose implicit in existentialism, but on the meaninglessness of existence. The universe is godless and meaningless, but more than that, it is indifferent to the existence of individual human beings. We feel that our lives should have significance, and search for meaning in our existence, but it is a fruitless search. For Camus, the demand for meaning is absurd. We must learn to accept that there is no meaning to life,

but this raises the question whether life is worth living at all – which he saw as the fundamental question of philosophy. Suicide, however, was no answer, merely a surrender. Better, he believed, to embrace the absurdity of existence and rebel against its injustice. Camus's ideas influenced dramatists of the 'theatre of the absurd' in the later 20th century, including Samuel Beckett (opposite), Eugène Ionesco, Edward Albee and Tom Stoppard.